

Critical Thinking (BES-103)



Week 5

Identifying/ Recognizing/ Evaluating Arguments

Hadiqua Fazal
Asst. Prof.
Computer Science
Department

Lecture Outline

- ▷ What is an argument?
- ▷ Identifying Premise and Conclusion
- ▷ Good and bad argument
- ▷ Persuasive Argument

What is an argument?

- ▷ When people hear the word argument, they usually think of some kind of quarrel or shouting match. In critical thinking, however, an argument is simply a claim defended with reason
- ▷ Arguments are composed of one or more **premises** and a **conclusion**.



Premises & Conclusion

Premises are statements in an argument offered as evidence or reasons why we should accept another statement, the conclusion.

Or

A premise is a statement in an argument that provides reason or support for the conclusion. There can be one or many premises in a single argument.

Conclusion

The **conclusion** is the statement in an argument that the premises are intended to prove or support.

Or

A conclusion is a statement in an argument that indicates what the arguer is trying to convince the reader/listener.

Identifying Premise and Conclusion

Here are some common premise indicators:

- | | |
|----------------------------|------------------|
| ▷ since | because |
| ▷ for | given that |
| ▷ seeing that | considering that |
| ▷ inasmuch as | as |
| ▷ in view of the fact that | as indicated by |

Identifying Premise and Conclusion

▷ And here are some common conclusion indicators:

▷ therefore

thus

▷ hence

consequently

▷ so

accordingly

▷ it follows that

for this reason

▷ that is why

which shows that

▷ wherefore

this implies that

▷ as a result

this suggests that

▷ this being so

we may infer that

Example 1

In the argument about Wynona mentioned above, the premises are “The law prohibits teachers from leading class prayers in public schools” and “Wynona leads students in prayer in her public school classroom.” The conclusion is “Therefore, Wynona is breaking the law.”

(The word therefore and synonyms such as so and consequently are often used to identify conclusions.

Example 2

Cats with long hair shed all over the house so you should not get a long-haired cat. I have heard that they also have lots of fleas.

Solution of Example 2

P¹ Long-haired cats shed all over the house

P² Long-haired cats have a lot of fleas

C You should not get a long haired cat

Example 3

I deserve a raise. I'm very good at my job.

P - I'm very good at my job

C - I deserve a raise

Example 4

Jesse is one year old. Most one-year-olds can walk. It follows that Jesse can walk.

Example 5

Since small fish is rich in calcium, it follows that your body will benefit if you eat them.

Premise: He is not good at his work.

Conclusion: He doesn't deserve a raise!

Good and Bad Argument

A good argument is one where the premises sufficiently support the belief the conclusion is true.

1. The premises are plausible. That is, you must have sufficient evidence to believe the premises are true.
2. The argument must be valid or strong.

Example

Should students be required to wear school uniforms?

Argument: School uniforms promote a sense of unity and equality among students, reduce peer pressure and social stigma based on clothing, and create a safer and more disciplined learning environment. However, they can also limit students' self-expression and creativity, be expensive for families, and fail to address the root causes of bullying and discrimination.

Bad Argument

- ▷ A bad argument is one where the premises do not provide good reasons to support the conclusion.
- ▷ Relies on emotional appeals or personal opinions rather than evidence and logic.
- ▷ Is based on inaccurate or unreliable information.

Example

Oprah Winfrey is the left-handed woman in the world therefore all lefties are intelligent.

Good or Bad Argument?

Topic: Cats are better pets than dogs.

Argument: Cats are better pets than dogs because they are quieter, more independent, and require less attention and exercise. Dogs are too loud, needy, and high-maintenance, and can be aggressive and dangerous.

Good or Bad?

- ▷ Topic: Climate change is a real and urgent threat to our planet.
- ▷ Argument: The overwhelming majority of scientists agree that climate change is real and caused by human activities such as burning fossil fuels and deforestation. Climate change is already causing severe consequences such as rising sea levels, extreme weather events, and biodiversity loss, and will have even more devastating impacts in the future if we do not take urgent action to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and transition to a sustainable and equitable society.

Persuasive Argument

A persuasive argument is a type of argument that aims to convince someone of a particular viewpoint or persuade them to take a certain action. Persuasive arguments typically use a combination of logic, reasoning, and emotional appeals to persuade the listener or reader.

Example

Topic: The importance of regular exercise for a healthy lifestyle.

Argument: Regular exercise is crucial for maintaining a healthy lifestyle. Exercise helps to improve cardiovascular health, increase muscle strength, reduce the risk of chronic diseases such as obesity, diabetes and heart disease, and improve mental health and overall well-being. Without regular exercise, our bodies become weaker and more prone to disease and injury, and our mental health suffers as well. It is therefore essential to make exercise a part of our daily routine, even if it's just a few minutes a day.

Positive or Negative?

- ▷ As in an ad trying to get you to buy something you don't need, peer pressure that causes you to make poor decisions, or even deliberate misinformation.
- ▷ Think of public service or health campaigns that urge people to recycle, quit smoking, or practice social distancing to help protect themselves and their community.